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Jumbo CABINET

India had 18 ministries in 1947. Nehru's cabinet had 22 ministers. Must the Government have 78 ministers? If 20 ministries, which are outdated and where the onus of implementation is with the states, are wound up, the Government could save over **Rs 75,000 crore**.

their concern". Laudable, even if symbolic, but it degenerated with ministers informing news channels of their "economy class travails". Finance Minister Pranab Mukherjee asked MPs to travel economy within India and business class (and not first class) abroad. The economy class boarding card was the new loyalty card.

Interestingly, the Department of Expenditure (DOE) raised the limits for renovation and furnishings of ministerial offices including their residential offices in July even though drought was very much on the horizon. A few weeks later on September 7, a four-page DOE notification targeted a cut of 10 per cent in non-plan expenditure. The harsh truth is that it has targeted similar cuts since 2006 and never achieved it. Despite ambitions to cut costs, between June 2004 and November 2007, ministers travelled 1.02 crore km, or 256 times around the earth. And between 2005 and 2008, officials travelled 5.65 crore km and stayed abroad for 24,458 days.

Even though by September the

For the Record

This is not the first year of the cost-cutting measure

Circular 7(1) E.Coord/2009 dated 7th September 2009: For 2009-10, every ministry/department shall effect a mandatory 10 per cent cut in non-Plan expenditure...

Circular 7(1) E.Coord/2008 dated June 5, 2008: For 2008-09, every ministry/department shall effect a mandatory 10 per cent cut in non-Plan expenditure...

Circular 7(2) E.Coord/2007 dated 17th September 2007: For 2007-08, every ministry/department shall make mandatory 5 per cent cut in non-Plan expenditure...

Circular 7(3) E.Coord/2006 dated 22nd July 2006: For 2006-07, every ministry/department shall make mandatory 5 per cent cut in non-Plan expenditure...

spectre of drought had receded considerably, the Union Cabinet on September 10 spent over an hour arguing whether the tokenism was justifiable. Logic and rationale was silenced with a combination of emotions and rhetoric. Congress-ruled states joined the race with the desert state of Rajasthan banning purchase of new air-conditioners among other items. By that weekend there was no stopping "competitive austerity".

In the modern world, austerity is really about enforcing the morality of productivity. India at Independence had just 18 departments. Is anybody questioning why we need over 85 today? Is there a correlation between manpower and productivity? Is a staff of 1,38,370 low or high to collect a revenue of Rs 6,41,079 crore? Why does the Environment Ministry need a secretary, two additional secretaries, six joint secretaries and two joint secretary-level officers? Do we need all the ministries we have? Why do we need a Ministry for Minority Affairs when we have a Ministry for